

Area of Study 2E – Hinduism

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Hinduism as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about the issues of peace and conflict, and crime and punishment.

There are four sections: Hindu Beliefs, Crime and Punishment, Living the Hindu Life and Peace and Conflict.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Hindus today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how scripture informs a Hindu's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Hinduism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Hinduism with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.5)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.4)*

Students should recognise that Hinduism is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Judaism, Islam, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Hinduism and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Hinduism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Hinduism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Shaivism and Vaishnavism.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of Brahman: The nature of Brahman as spirit, ultimate reality or absolute truth; how the characteristics of Brahman are shown in Hindu scriptures, including Katha Upanishad 2.2.6–8.
1.2	The nature and importance of understanding Brahman as Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Brahman: how Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Brahman are shown in Hindu scripture, for example Nirguna (Taaittiriya Upanishad 2.7.1–2) and Saguna (Rig Veda 1.154.1–2); the nature and importance of Vaikuntha (spiritual worlds); divergent ways in which belief in each may be expressed in the life of Hindus today.
1.3	Three aspects of the divine: Brahman, Antaryami and Bhagavan; the nature and significance of the divine as Brahman (everywhere and non-personal), Antaryami (within the heart) and Bhagavan (beyond, as a personal loving God); how the three aspects are shown in Hindu scriptures, including Mundaka Upanishad 2.1; why belief in the three aspects of the divine are important in Hindu life and for religious pluralism today.
1.4	Manifestations of the Divine: the nature and importance of how the deities are shown in Hindu scriptures; avatars and murti; the nature and role of male deities: divergent understandings of the importance of Vishnu (including Rig Veda 1.22) and Shiva; the nature and role of the female force, Shakti, including Parvati and Lakshmi.
1.5*	The nature of the individual and life within Hinduism: the nature and importance of the atman (eternal self), karma, the cycle of samsara, moksha; divergent Hindu understandings of the nature of the individual and life, including interpretations of Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 4.4; why beliefs about the atman, karma, samsara and moksha are important for Hindus today.
1.6	The purpose of human life for Hindus: the nature and significance of the four aims of life (Purusharthas) – dharma, artha, kama and moksha; the nature and significance of anatana dharma (eternal law), including Bhagavad Gita 3.35; the nature and significance of varnashrama dharma (duties according to materialistic situation in life).
1.7	Hindu responses to suffering, knowledge and ignorance: Hindu teachings about suffering, knowledge and ignorance such as ahimsa, respect, empathy, mind/sense control, humility, and love, including Mahabharata 5.39; divergent Hindu understandings as to why there is suffering, knowledge and ignorance for Hindus today.
1.8	Hindu cosmology: the nature of the Hindu cosmology as shown in Hindu scriptures, including Rig Veda 10.129; the nature and importance of the cycle of four ages (yugas), including descriptions of the Kali Yuga in the Mahabharata, many worlds and their diverse inhabitants; the nature and divergent understandings of the importance of the concepts of prakriti (matter/nature), tri-guna (three qualities) and maya (illusion).

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Hindu attitudes towards justice: the nature of justice and why justice is important for Hindus, including Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 5.2; Hindu teachings about why justice is important for the victim; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why justice is important, regardless of religion and belief, and Hindu responses to them.
2.2	Hindu attitudes towards crime: Hindu teachings about and responses to the nature, causes and problem of crime, including interpretations of Bhagavad Gita 14.16–18; what action is taken by Hindu individuals and Hindu groups to end the causes of crime, for example the work of BAPS charities.
2.3	Hindu teachings about good, evil and suffering: Hindu teachings about the nature of good actions and how they are rewarded, and teachings about the nature of evil actions and how they are punished, including Bhagavata Purana 4; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why people suffer, including believing in religion, and Hindu responses to them; divergent Hindu teachings about why people suffer.
2.4	Hindu attitudes towards punishment: the nature of punishment; teachings about why punishment is important for Hindus, including reference to Manusmriti 7.13–28, and about the nature and meaning of danda and prayascitta; Hindu teachings about why punishment can be regarded as justice, why punishment might be needed in society.
2.5	Hindu attitudes towards the aims of punishment: divergent Hindu attitudes towards each of the aims of punishment (protection, retribution, deterrence and reformation); the nature and meaning of Hindu teachings about punishment, including Bhagavad Gita 4.35–37.
2.6	Hindu teachings about forgiveness: Hindu teachings and responses about the nature of forgiveness; how offenders are forgiven by the community and why this is needed; Hindu teachings and responses to the nature and use of restorative justice and why it is important for criminals, including Mahabharata 3.29.
2.7	Hindu teachings about the treatment of criminals: Hindu teachings about the treatment of criminals, including Mahabharata 13.117; divergent Hindu attitudes towards the use of torture, human rights, fair trial and trial by jury; the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, which may accept the use of torture if it is for the greater good.
2.8	Hindu attitudes towards the death penalty: the nature and purpose of capital punishment; divergent Hindu attitudes and teachings about capital punishment, including interpretations of Padma Purana 1.31; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards the use of capital punishment, including the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, and Hindu responses to them.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	The nature and purpose of Hindu yoga: the nature and purpose of different forms of yoga: karma yoga (action), jnana yoga (knowledge), astanga/raja yoga (meditation) and bhakti yoga (devotion); examples of when each form of yoga might be used, how and why; the importance of having different types of yoga; reference to Bhagavad Gita 6.44–47.
3.2	Focuses of worship and representations of the divine: the nature, purpose and importance of different ways of worshipping, including worshipping one god (personal or non-personal) or many deities, gurus and holy places (land, hills, rivers and sacred plants and animals); the scriptural basis for the different focuses of worship and representations of the divine in worship, including interpretations of Bhagavad Gita 6.20–31.
3.3	The importance of Hindu places of worship: the nature, features of, use, and purpose of worship in different places, including in the temple, in the home, outside, shrines and festival celebration and in the space of the heart, with reference to interpretations of Bhagavad Gita 9.13–27; the benefits for Hindus of having different places to worship in.
3.4*	The nature and purpose of prayer in the temple and the home: the nature, features of use and purpose of the different forms of worship, including meditation, puja, havan, darshan, arti, bhajan, kirtan and japa, with reference to interpretations of Bhagavad Gita 6.44–47; divergent understandings of the benefits for Hindus of having different forms of worship.
3.5	Hindu sacred festivals: the nature, history, purpose and significance of Hindu sacred festivals; the origins and meaning of specific festivals, including Diwali, Holi, Navratri Dussehra, Ram Navami, Ratha-yatra, Janmashtami, and Raksha Bandhan, including interpretations of Brhadaranyaka Upanishad 1.3.28.
3.6	Hindu pilgrimage: the nature, history and purpose of Hindu pilgrimages; the significance of the places Hindus go on pilgrimage; divergent understandings of why pilgrimage may, or may not be, important for Hindus today; the nature, features, history and importance of pilgrimage to the Ganges, including interpretations of Rig Veda 10.75, Vrindavana and Varanasi.
3.7	Hindu environmental projects: divergent understandings of the nature, purpose and significance of environmental care for Hindus; the importance of care for rivers and sacred places for Hindus; how Hindus care for the environment, examples of what they do and why, including reference to cow protection and interpretations of Rig Veda 10.87.16–19.
3.8	Hindu charity work: the nature and purpose of charity for Hindus; Hindu teachings about charity; the work of one named Hindu charity working to promote wellbeing, social inclusion and women's rights, what it does and why, including interpretations of Bhagavad Gita 3.10–12.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Hindu attitudes towards peace: the nature of peace; divergent Hindu attitudes towards the importance of peace; Hindu teachings about peace, including Bhagavad Gita 1.65–67.
4.2	The role of Hindus in peacemaking: Hindu teachings about peacemaking; the importance of justice, forgiveness and reconciliation for Hindus in peacemaking; the work of Hindus working for peace today, what they do and why they try to work for peace, including teachings on ahimsa in Artharva Veda 10.191.4 and the work of Mahatma Gandhi.
4.3	Hindu attitudes to conflict: Hindu teachings and responses to the problems conflict causes within society; Hindu responses to the problems conflict causes, including Rig Veda 10.191; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes about the role of religion in the causes of conflict and Hindu responses to them.
4.4	Hindu attitudes to pacifism: Hindu teachings and responses to the nature and history of pacifism, including the ideas of Mahatma Gandhi; divergent Hindu teachings about passive resistance, including Rig Veda 10.191.4 and satyagraha and the example of Mahatma Gandhi.
4.5	Hindu attitudes to the Just War theory: Hindu teachings and responses about the nature, history and importance of the Just War theory; the conditions of a Just War; divergent Hindu opinions about whether a Just War is possible, including Bhagavad Gita 2.31–38; the application of ethical theories such as situation ethics.
4.6	Hindu attitudes to Holy War: Hindu teachings and responses about the nature of a Holy War; the nature and meaning of Hindu teachings about war and peace; Hindu teachings about not killing and when fighting is a person's duty, including Bhagavad Gita 2.31–39.
4.7	Hindu attitudes to weapons of mass destruction (WMD): Hindu teachings and responses to the problems and benefits of WMD; Hindu attitudes towards the use of such weapons, including Bhagavad Gita 13.26–33; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) and the application of ethical theories (such as utilitarianism) which support the acquisition of weapons of mass destruction, and Hindu responses to them.
4.8	Hindu attitudes to issues surrounding conflict: Hindu teachings and responses to the nature and history of problems involved in conflict – violence, war and terrorism, including Bhagavad Gita 11; how Hindus have worked to overcome these issues; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) views towards the issues surrounding conflict and Hindu responses to them.